Dhawan respected him for his scientific insights as much for the fact that Brahm Prakash was senior to Dhawan.

If Brahm Prakash said something, even ISRO chairman Dhawan wouldn't oppose. But ground-testing of Vikas needed Dhawan's approval—and clearance from the PMO. I am not sure what was in Dhawan's mind, but he still gave the proponents of solid-only versions of PSLV a long rope. And they were to reach the end of that rope soon. In one of the planning group discussions attended by Brahm Prakash, one presentation after another turned out to be short of expectations.

One of the configurations of PSLV came close to the goal, but it was found to have high levels of instability because of the thrust.

'Hey, Dathan, can you bring down the propulsion a bit,' said Kalam.

'I can,' replied Dathan, 'but you will have to bring down the payload weight a bit.'

Kalam fell silent. Finally, Brahm Prakash stood up.

'I think we have no option but to go in for a liquid engine.'

Somewhere in my mind, Vikas smiled.